

Advanced Placement United States History

Unit 2 Long Essay Question (LEQ)

The long essay question requires students to do the following:

Respond to the prompt with a historically defensible thesis or claim that establishes a line of reasoning.

Describe a broader historical context relevant to the prompt.

Support an argument in response to the prompt using at least two pieces of specific and relevant evidence.

Demonstrate a complex understanding of a historical development related to the prompt through sophisticated argumentation and/or effective use of evidence.

Introductory statement:

After the French and Indian War, Great Britain tightened its control over its North American colonies, and colonists developed new and increasingly organized ways to resist British authority.

Prompt:

Evaluate the extent to which British imperial policies influenced the development of colonial resistance in British North America during the period from 1754 to 1776.

Students might consider the French and Indian War, the Proclamation of 1763, the Stamp Act, the Townshend Acts, the Committees of Correspondence, the Coercive Acts, or the First Continental Congress.

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Introductory statement:

In the early 1700s Great Britain governed its North American colonies loosely, but by the end of the eighteenth century the colonies had won their independence.

Prompt:

Evaluate the extent to which the relationship between Great Britain and its North American colonies changed during the period from 1720 to 1783.

Students might consider salutary neglect, the French and Indian War, the Albany Plan of Union, the Stamp Act and the Declaratory Act, the Second Continental Congress, the Declaration of Independence, or the Treaty of Paris (1783).

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Introductory statement:

Colonists who first protested British taxes as loyal subjects increasingly justified their resistance with ideas about representation and natural rights.

Prompt:

Evaluate the extent to which ideas about rights and representation influenced the movement toward independence in British North America during the period from 1763 to 1776.

Students might consider virtual and actual representation, the Real Whigs, John Locke, the Stamp Act Congress, the Declaration of Rights and Grievances, Common Sense, or the Declaration of Independence.

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Introductory statement:

The Continental Army faced the most powerful military in the world, yet the colonists won their independence with help from abroad.

Prompt:

Evaluate the extent to which foreign assistance influenced the outcome of the American Revolution during the period from 1775 to 1783.

Students might consider the Second Continental Congress, George Washington's strategy, the Battle of Saratoga, the Franco-American Alliance, the war in the South, the Battle of Yorktown, or the Treaty of Paris (1783).

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Demonstrate a complex understanding of a historical development related to the prompt through sophisticated argumentation and/or effective use of evidence.

Introductory statement:

During the eighteenth century, immigration and religious revival changed the makeup and the beliefs of colonial society in British North America.

Prompt:

Evaluate the extent to which immigration and religious revival changed colonial society in British North America during the period from 1720 to 1776.

Students might consider natural increase, enslaved Africans, German and Scots-Irish immigration, Jonathan Edwards, George Whitefield, New Lights and Old Lights, or religious toleration.

Grading sheet (use for any practice prompt)

The AP LEQ rubric has six points. In this class each of the six points has been graded out of 10, so an essay is out of 60. Score your practice essay row by row.

rubric row	what earns it	score
A. Thesis/claim (0 to 1)	defensible thesis with a line of reasoning; class rule: last sentence of the contextualization paragraph	____ / 10
B. Contextualization (0 to 1)	broader context, at least four sentences, about 20 years before the prompt, flowing into the thesis	____ / 10
C. Evidence, point 1	at least two specific examples relevant to the topic	____ / 10
C. Evidence, point 2	at least two specific examples used to support the argument (each one linked to the thesis)	____ / 10
D. Analysis, point 1	the reasoning the prompt asks for (causation, comparison, or continuity and change) frames the essay	____ / 10
D. Analysis, point 2	complex understanding as part of the argument: at least four linked pieces of evidence, both sides, multiple causes, or connections across periods	____ / 10
Total	60 points, converted straight to a percentage (example: 54 / 60 = 90)	____ / 60

Structure the class expects

- Paragraph 1: contextualization, at least four sentences, ending with the thesis as its last sentence.
- One body paragraph per reason in the thesis, in the same order; every sentence ties back to the thesis.
- At least two specific, dated pieces of evidence per body paragraph, each followed by a sentence that says what it proves.
- Use the reasoning the prompt asks for. "Extent" means argue how much, not just whether.
- Complexity: four or more linked pieces of evidence, plus a real limit or second cause.
- Conclusion optional. Say "thesis." Avoid "always" and "never." Watch dates (1763 vs 1783, 1775 vs 1776, 1781 vs 1783).

Key · Practice prompt 1

Evaluate the extent to which British imperial policies influenced the development of colonial resistance in British North America during the period from 1754 to 1776.

Why practice this one

Covers the material the unit spends the most time on: each British policy after the French and Indian War, why Parliament passed it, why colonists objected, and what followed.

Reasoning to use

Causation (extent). Rank the policies and show each one produced a bigger, more organized response.

Contextualization paragraph (four sentences, then the thesis)

1. For decades Britain governed its colonies through salutary neglect: trade laws such as the Molasses Act (1733) went unenforced, and colonial assemblies controlled their own taxes.
2. Colonial population grew rapidly through natural increase, and German and Scots-Irish settlers pushed toward the backcountry and the Ohio Valley, land France also claimed.
3. The First Great Awakening of the 1730s and 1740s split congregations and taught ordinary colonists to question established authority.
4. Still, the colonies stayed divided: in 1754 every assembly rejected the Albany Plan of Union.
5. THESIS (last sentence of this paragraph).

Thesis

British imperial policies influenced the development of colonial resistance to a large extent, because the debt from the French and Indian War led Parliament to tax the colonies for revenue and then punish Massachusetts, and each new policy produced a larger and more organized colonial response; however, colonial beliefs about actual representation explain why those policies were seen as tyranny.

Body 1 · The war ends salutary neglect (1754 to 1764)

- French and Indian War (1754 to 1763): Britain wins but is deep in debt. Link: the debt is why Parliament now wants revenue from the colonies.
- Proclamation of 1763 after Pontiac's Rebellion: no settlement west of the Appalachians. Link: British policy now limits colonists' land, not only their trade.
- Sugar Act and Currency Act (1764): revenue duty enforced, no colonial paper money. Link: enforcement replaces neglect, and protest begins.

Body 2 · Taxes create organized resistance (1765 to 1770)

- Stamp Act (1765): Sons of Liberty, boycotts, and the Stamp Act Congress of 9 colonies; repealed in 1766, but the Declaratory Act keeps Parliament's claim. Link: a direct tax produces the first joint colonial action.
- Townshend Acts (1767): duties pay royal officials; John Dickinson's letters, the Daughters of Liberty and new boycotts; troops sent to Boston, then the Boston Massacre (1770). Link: each tax widens who resists and how.

Body 3 · Punishment unites the colonies (1772 to 1776)

- Committees of Correspondence (1772) and the Tea Act and Boston Tea Party (1773). Link: resistance becomes an intercolonial network.
- Coercive Acts (1774) close Boston's port and gut the Massachusetts charter; the First Continental Congress answers with the Declaration of Rights and Grievances and a boycott. Link: the punishment meant to isolate Boston unites the colonies.
- Lexington and Concord (1775), then Common Sense and the Declaration of Independence (1776). Link: resistance ends in independence.

Complexity (the row most people lose)

- Weigh a second cause: virtual vs. actual representation and the Real Whig fear of power explain why the same taxes looked like a plot against liberty.
- Limit the extent: until 1775 colonists still sought their rights as Englishmen (Olive Branch Petition), and about one in five colonists stayed Loyalist.
- Use at least four specific, linked pieces of evidence across the bodies.

Key · Practice prompt 2

Evaluate the extent to which the relationship between Great Britain and its North American colonies changed during the period from 1720 to 1783.

Why practice this one

Uses the whole unit, 1720 to 1783, as one continuity-and-change question, so evidence has to come from the start, middle and end of the period.

Reasoning to use

Continuity and change over time. Show what changed AND what stayed the same.

Contextualization paragraph (four sentences, then the thesis)

1. After the Glorious Revolution (1688), England restored colonial assemblies and ended the Dominion of New England.
2. Under mercantilism the Navigation Acts were meant to make the colonies serve England's economy.
3. Britain and France fought King William's War and Queen Anne's War (1702 to 1713) over North America, settling nothing.
4. By 1720 the colonies were loyal British subjects who largely ran their own affairs.
5. THESIS (last sentence of this paragraph).

Thesis

The relationship between Great Britain and its colonies changed to a great extent, from loose rule under salutary neglect to open war and independence, because the French and Indian War led Britain to tax and control the colonies directly; however, the colonists' claim to govern themselves through their own elected assemblies stayed the same, and that continuity is what turned new policies into a break.

Body 1 · Loose ties (1720 to 1754)

- Salutary neglect: trade laws barely enforced; the Molasses Act (1733) went unenforced. Link: colonists grew used to self-government.
- Albany Plan of Union (1754) rejected by every assembly. Link: the colonies were still separate and loyal, not united against Britain.

Body 2 · Tightening control (1754 to 1774)

- French and Indian War (1754 to 1763) and the Treaty of Paris (1763): France leaves, Britain is in debt. Link: the turning point that ends neglect.
- Stamp Act (1765) and the Declaratory Act (1766): Parliament claims power "in all cases whatsoever." Link: the relationship becomes a fight over who may tax the colonies.
- Coercive Acts (1774): Massachusetts punished. Link: control by force replaces negotiation.

Body 3 · The break (1775 to 1783)

- Second Continental Congress (1775): Washington named commander; the Olive Branch Petition is refused. Link: the colonies act as a government of their own.
- Declaration of Independence (1776) and the Treaty of Paris (1783): independence, recognized by Britain. Link: the relationship ends in separation.

Complexity (the row most people lose)

- Both change and continuity: the argument about representation and self-government runs from salutary neglect through the Declaration.
- Precision: Yorktown (1781) is the decisive surrender, but Britain recognizes independence in the Treaty of Paris (1783).
- Limit: Loyalists and Britain's Native allies did not share the colonists' new independence.

Key · Practice prompt 3

Evaluate the extent to which ideas about rights and representation influenced the movement toward independence in British North America during the period from 1763 to 1776.

Why practice this one

The ideas behind the resistance are the strongest second cause to weigh against British policy, and the Declaration of Independence sits at the end of the chain.

Reasoning to use

Causation (extent): ideas as a cause, weighed against British policies and the fighting.

Contextualization paragraph (four sentences, then the thesis)

1. Britain won the French and Indian War in 1763 but was left deeply in debt.
2. For decades colonial assemblies had controlled their own taxes under salutary neglect.
3. The First Great Awakening had already taught colonists to question established authority.
4. Pontiac's Rebellion and the Proclamation of 1763 showed that London now meant to manage the colonies directly.
5. THESIS (last sentence of this paragraph).

Thesis

Ideas about rights and representation influenced the movement toward independence to a large extent, because the colonists' belief in actual representation turned British taxes into a constitutional crisis and John Locke's natural rights justified the final break; however, ideas alone did not cause independence, since British policies and the fighting that began in 1775 forced the decision.

Body 1 · Representation (1765 to 1774)

- Virtual representation (Britain) vs. actual representation (colonists): only elected assemblies could tax. Link: this is why the Stamp Act (1765) was rejected on principle.
- Stamp Act Congress (1765) and the First Continental Congress's Declaration of Rights and Grievances (1774): trade regulation accepted, revenue taxes rejected. Link: the protest rested on an idea, not just the cost.

Body 2 · Fear of power

- Real Whigs: English writers who warned that concentrated power threatens liberty. Link: each act looked like part of a plot.
- Townshend Acts (1767) paid royal officials, threatening the assemblies' power of the purse; the Coercive Acts (1774) gutted the Massachusetts charter. Link: colonists read both as proof of the plot.

Body 3 · Natural rights and independence (1776)

- Common Sense (1776): Thomas Paine's plain argument for independence. Link: shifts opinion from rights as Englishmen to a break.
- Declaration of Independence (1776): Locke's natural rights, consent of the governed, the right to alter or abolish, grievances against the king. Link: the ideas become the justification for independence.

Complexity (the row most people lose)

- Change over time: from rights as Englishmen (Declaration of the Causes and Necessity of Taking Up Arms and the Olive Branch Petition, 1775) to natural rights (1776).
- Weigh the other cause: the king's refusal of the Olive Branch and the fighting at Lexington and Concord pushed colonists toward the ideas they then used.
- Limit: these ideas did not extend to enslaved people; Dunmore's Proclamation (1775) offered freedom from the British side.

Key · Practice prompt 4

Evaluate the extent to which foreign assistance influenced the outcome of the American Revolution during the period from 1775 to 1783.

Why practice this one

Covers Chapter 6: why the colonists won, with Saratoga and the French alliance at the center.

Reasoning to use

Causation (extent): weigh foreign help against American strategy and British problems.

Contextualization paragraph (four sentences, then the thesis)

1. The French and Indian War gave colonists military experience, including a young George Washington at Fort Mifflin (1754).
2. Britain's war debt led to taxes that colonists resisted from 1765 on.
3. The Coercive Acts (1774) led to the First Continental Congress.
4. Fighting began at Lexington and Concord in 1775, against the strongest navy and a professional army.
5. THESIS (last sentence of this paragraph).

Thesis

Foreign assistance influenced the outcome of the American Revolution to a large extent, because after Saratoga the French alliance supplied troops, money and a navy that made the decisive victory at Yorktown possible; however, the Americans first had to survive on their own, through Washington's strategy of avoiding decisive losses and a Second Continental Congress that kept the war going.

Body 1 · Surviving alone (1775 to 1777)

- Second Continental Congress (1775): names Washington commander and prints paper money. Link: a government kept the war alive.
- Washington's strategy: avoid decisive losses and keep the army together; home ground meant British supplies crossed an ocean. Link: survival made foreign help possible.

Body 2 · Saratoga brings France (1777 to 1778)

- Saratoga (1777): a whole British army surrenders. Link: proves the Americans can win.
- Franco-American Alliance (1778): troops, advisors, gunpowder and a navy that could challenge Britain's. Link: Britain now fights a world power.

Body 3 · The South and Yorktown (1778 to 1783)

- After Saratoga Britain moves the war South, expecting Loyalist support, but fails to hold the countryside. Link: Britain could win battles without winning control.
- Yorktown (1781): the French navy and an allied army trap a British army; Britain stops offensive operations. The Treaty of Paris (1783) recognizes independence. Link: foreign help produced the decisive end.

Complexity (the row most people lose)

- The causes depended on each other: survival led to Saratoga, Saratoga to the alliance, the alliance to Yorktown.
- Precision: Spain fought Britain but did not ally with the United States.
- Other perspective: British and Hessian looting pushed neutrals toward the Patriots.

Key · Practice prompt 5

Evaluate the extent to which immigration and religious revival changed colonial society in British North America during the period from 1720 to 1776.

Why practice this one

Covers Chapter 4, colonial society before the imperial crisis, and connects it to what followed.

Reasoning to use

Continuity and change (extent): what society became, and what stayed the same.

Contextualization paragraph (four sentences, then the thesis)

1. By 1700 the colonies were mostly English settlements along the coast.
2. The Chesapeake and South Carolina had become slave societies, while New England remained a society with slaves.
3. Established churches, Puritan in New England and Anglican in the South, shaped colonial life.
4. After the Glorious Revolution the colonists saw themselves as loyal Protestant British subjects.
5. THESIS (last sentence of this paragraph).

Thesis

Immigration and religious revival changed colonial society to a large extent, because German and Scots-Irish immigrants and enslaved Africans made the colonies far more diverse and the First Great Awakening split the established churches and encouraged colonists to question authority; however, colonists remained loyal British subjects into the 1760s, and slavery and the power of local elites continued.

Body 1 · Growth and forced migration

- Natural increase: most of the population growth came from births, not immigration. Link: a fast-growing population pushed west for land.
- Enslaved Africans were the largest group of newcomers, involuntary migrants. Link: slavery grew alongside the free population.

Body 2 · A less English society

- German and Scots-Irish immigrants, most after 1730, many to Pennsylvania and the backcountry. Link: the colonies became more diverse and less English.
- Backcountry settlement pressed on western land. Link: this connects to the land conflicts behind the Proclamation of 1763.

Body 3 · The First Great Awakening (1730s to 1740s)

- Jonathan Edwards ("Sinners in the Hands of an Angry God") and George Whitefield, an itinerant preacher who drew huge crowds. Link: emotional, personal religion reached ordinary colonists.
- New Lights vs. Old Lights: congregations split, denominations multiplied, toleration grew. Link: authority could be challenged from below.

Complexity (the row most people lose)

- Connection to the next period: argue that the habit of questioning authority carried into the resistance after 1763; present it as an argument, with evidence.
- Continuity: colonists stayed loyal subjects, and slavery expanded rather than weakened.
- Use at least four specific, linked pieces of evidence.

How these practice prompts are set up

- **The layout:** each prompt page follows a class LEQ handout: the four task lines in italics, an introductory statement, one prompt, and a "Students might consider" list. One prompt, no choice.
- **The introductory statement** sets up the context and points toward the argument. Use it to start your contextualization paragraph, then go beyond it.
- **The "Students might consider" list** runs in rough time order. Use the items as evidence for your body paragraphs; you do not need all of them, and you can add others from the unit.
- **The time spans are broad.** Plan evidence from the start, the middle and the end of the period the prompt names.
- **The plans** after the prompts show one way to answer each: context ending in the thesis, three body paragraphs with dated evidence and the link to the thesis, and a complexity move.
- **Practice the way it is graded:** write one prompt in a blue book under timed conditions, then score it with the grading sheet.

These are original practice prompts written from the course's chapters 4 to 6 (1720 to 1783). They are not the real prompt, and nothing here is copied from an actual assessment beyond the handout's layout.